make art for the market," he replies, tersely. "No artist makes art for the market. My art is not by demand."

Gupta's art may not be a commodity, but he might find it hard to contest the fact that it does remain much in demand. His sculptures have found place in key collections, in India and abroad. With entrepreneurial instincts that match his artistic ability, Gupta has helped transform the profile of the modern artist—from 'tortured and impoverished' to 'rich and famous'. Since there was nobody else like him—perhaps, only M.F. Husain—the press once nicknamed him the 'Damien Hirst of New Delhi'. Today, he rebuffs the comparison: "I'm an international artist. I have my own identity and signature."

Born in Khagaul and educated at the College of Arts and Crafts in Patna, Gupta was always confident he would make it. The only thing he didn't expect was the magnitude of his success. Ironically, for an artist whose methods are often equated with those of the irreverent Frenchman Marcel Duchamp, Gupta reminds us that his college didn't even have a single art history class. The upside was he could break with tradition. He says, "We didn't grow up reading about Duchamp, Picasso or Matisse. All this came to us much later." Only after he had moved to Delhi in 1989 did Gupta get fully exposed to western art.

Meeting his wife Bharti Kher for the first time in 1992 was a turning point for Gupta, both personally and professionally. "Bharti was instrumental in introducing me to a new world," says Gupta, suddenly breaking into Hindi. While Hindi remains his primary language of expression, he says he wants to create the kind of art that thrives on his legacy of being Indian. He adds, "*Nasha kaam banane mein hai, dost* [The intoxication is in creating a work, my friend]. I don't know how else to explain it." ■

–Shaikh Ayaz



THERE IS NOW A WALL

RATHIN BARMAN

Experimenter–Hindustan Road, Kolkata

On till March 26, 2022

The title of the exhibition alludes to a conversation between two squabbling brothers who divide their home by erecting a wall in the centre of its courtyard. It is sculpture at its playful best.



ART

A still from *Dante Katha*; (below, clockwise from left) artworks by Liliana Angulo Cortes; Vvzela Kook; and Cian Dayrit

Bursting the Canon

The Kathmandu Triennale hopes to decolonise art with its focus on heritage and indigenous practices

In 2019, the LAB Collective was born in Darjeeling after a group of fresh graduates from the National Institute of Design, Ahmedabad, decided to collaborate to tell stories that mattered. Filmmaker Dishant Pradhan, for instance, felt that many things in Darjeeling itself deserved to be seen more, like "Darjeeling's history of identity crisis, colonialism and the movement for separate statehood". What emerged is a Nepali short film titled *Dante Katha*, or oral storytelling. Seen through the eyes of a little girl looking for her missing brother, the film helps you traverse forests, mountains, hear folk tales from the Himalayan regions, all the while transporting you to a magic-realist setting. Along with a zine and a textile installation, LAB is now showing *Dante Katha* at the Kathmandu Triennale (on till March 31).







Dante Katha fits perfectly with the event's larger, overarching theme of decolonisation. With a participation of over 50 artists from more than 25 countries, the event, curated by artistic director Cosmin Costinas, Sheelasha Rajbhandari and Hit Man Gurung, is being pitted as "the largest presentation of contemporary art in Nepal to date". Other themes of the Triennale include migration, displacement and indigenous knowledge; basically, art that goes beyond the Eurocentric canon. Take, for instance, the Hong Kong-based new media artist Vvzela Kook's video 'Columbus of Horticulture', which explores the role of botany in the history of imperialism. Or the Philippine artist Cian Dayrit who "traces the geography of power and the course of empire" through a large handsewn map, in a piece titled 'Valley of Dispossession'. "We wanted to whittle away the parameters drawn on contemporary art that discourage access to indigenous practices, mediums and intangible heritage," says Rajbhandari.

Organised by the Nepal's ministry of culture, tourism and civil aviation and the Siddhartha Arts Foundation, the Triennale will stretch across five venues, each chosen for the context it provides to the 300-odd artworks on display. The exhibition showcasing the ideas and practices of mapping, navigation and cartography is, for example, being hosted inside a former war room that was once used for military strategy and expansion. "[The idea is] to reveal a range of cultural vocabularies of self, body and universe," says Hit Man Gurung. ■

(For a virtual tour of the Kathmandu Triennale, visit Kathmandutriennale.org)

–Sukhada Tatke